Debate Topics Made Easy

Nov 3, 2026 · @Nathan S.

This is a simple guide to the five debate motions. For each one you get what the motion means, the two big clashes, what each side argues, and how the other side answers. Everything comes from the Day 1 readings and Day 2 Clash Points in the books.

How to read the tables: *Proposition* (Government) agrees with the motion. *Opposition* disagrees. In each clash, read across: one side's argument, then the other side's answer.

1. Rent freezes (January)

Motion: THBT rent freezes are a form of harmful populism.

What it means: A *rent freeze* is a rule that stops rent from going up for a certain time. *Populism* here means a policy that sounds good to many people now but causes problems later. Proposition says rent freezes are this kind of harmful policy. Opposition says they are a useful way to protect people.

Clash 1 — Economic: Do rent freezes hurt or help the housing market?

Proposition says	Rent freezes **distort the market**. When landlords cannot raise rent, they earn less. Some stop renting their homes, and some stop fixing them. So there are fewer homes to rent, and rent jumps later. *Example: Berlin, Germany (2019).*
Opposition answers	Rent freezes keep the economy stable. When rent stays the same, people have more money to spend at local shops, which helps the economy.
Opposition says	Rent freezes are an **economic stability measure**. When housing costs rise too fast, a freeze takes money pressure off families and keeps the market steady for a while. *Example: Barcelona, Spain.*
Proposition answers	Landlords earn less, so fewer homes are rented and rent can rise a lot later. If the government builds public housing or gives money to help, taxes may go up.

Clash 2 — Social: Who is protected, and who is left out?

Proposition says	Rent freezes **cause social inequality**. They help people who already rent. New renters, like young people and newlyweds, face fewer homes and higher rent. This is unfair between generations. *Example: Barcelona, Spain.*
Opposition answers	Without rules, rent can rise faster than people's income. A freeze gives short-term safety to young people and low-income people.
Opposition says	Rent freezes **protect the vulnerable**. They keep housing affordable, so people with different incomes can live together. *Example: Vienna, Austria (strong rent rules and public housing).*
Proposition answers	The policy only helps people who already rent. New renters have fewer choices, so it is harder for them to improve their lives.

2. Humanoid robots like Atlas (March)

Motion: THBT humanoid robots like Atlas must be restricted from fully replacing humans in automobile factories.

What it means: Atlas is a *humanoid* robot, which means it is shaped like a person. It can now do hard work in car factories. Proposition wants rules that stop robots from taking **all** the jobs. Opposition says companies should be free to use robots.

Clash 1 — Social: Does fast automation break society or move it forward?

Proposition says	We need limits for **social stability and worker protection**. Many people can lose their jobs at once, and factory workers cannot quickly move to high-skill jobs. Inequality grows and local towns get weaker. Limits give society time to adjust. *Example: Amazon warehouses.*

Opposition answers	Technology has always **changed** jobs, not just removed them. Robots take dangerous work, and workers move to better roles. We should fix unemployment with training, not by stopping technology.
Opposition says	Robots are not the only cause of lost jobs. A lack of retraining is also a cause. Governments and companies have a **shared responsibility** to help workers move to new jobs. *Examples: Tesla (workers moved to safer roles), Microsoft (new IT jobs).*
Proposition answers	Humanoid robots replace workers **fast and on a large scale**. Factory workers cannot become robot engineers overnight. Training takes time, but job loss happens right away.

Clash 2 — Economic: Which matters more for growth, efficiency or customers who can buy?

Proposition says	Limits protect **market stability and long-term growth**. If many people lose jobs, they spend less. Products have little value if no one can buy them. Welfare costs go up, and big companies push small ones out. *Examples: Foxconn, General Motors.*
Opposition answers	Robots lower costs, so prices drop and more people can buy things. Higher profits mean more taxes to pay for training and welfare. Limiting robots slows growth.
Opposition says	Robots bring **productivity and competitiveness**. Companies need them to compete with other countries, and robots create new industries like robotics and AI. *Examples: BMW (used tax money for worker training), Toss (flexible rules helped it grow).*
Proposition answers	High productivity means little **without consumers**. Mass unemployment cuts spending, and short-term efficiency can cause long-term problems.

3. Excess profits to workers (July)

Motion: THBT companies' excess profits should be distributed to workers before shareholders.

What it means: *Excess profits* are profits that are bigger than expected. *Shareholders* own parts of a company because they invested money in it. The question is who should get the extra money **first**: the workers who did the work, or the shareholders who took the risk. The books use the 2026 Samsung Electronics bonus agreement as the main example.

Clash 1 — Social: Who deserves the reward, workers or shareholders?

Proposition says	It is a **fair reward for labor**. Workers make the products and keep the company running every day. Many workers live on their wages, while shareholders often invest money they already have. If profits go only to shareholders, the gap between rich and working people grows. *Example: Samsung's 2026 deal with its union included performance bonuses.*
Opposition answers	Fairness should also **reward investment risk**. Shareholders give the company money to build factories, make products and hire workers. If the company fails, they can lose that money.
Opposition says	It creates **new inequality among workers**. Workers at big, successful companies are already paid well. Workers at small businesses, subcontractors and temporary workers get nothing. *Example: Samsung's 2026 bonuses went to chip workers, but other workers were left out.*
Proposition answers	Big-company workers still helped create those profits. Companies can design the policy to include subcontracted and temporary workers. The problem is how the system is designed, not sharing itself.

Clash 2 — Economic: Does sharing profits grow or shrink the company in the long run?

Proposition says	Sharing brings **more spending and productivity**. Workers spend extra money on food, housing and education, so money goes back into the market. Rewarded workers are more motivated and loyal, and they work better. *Examples: profit-sharing, employee stock ownership plans (ESOPs), efficiency wage theory.*
Opposition answers	Extra spending helps only **in the short term**. Companies also need money for factories, research and new technology to stay competitive.
Opposition says	It means **less investment and growth**. If shareholders get less, investors move their money elsewhere. Big bonuses are hard to cut later, even in bad times. *Example: Samsung also needed huge investment in chip factories, research and AI factories.*
Proposition answers	Growth also depends on **skilled, motivated, loyal workers**. When workers feel their work is recognized, they work harder and stay longer. Rewarding workers is also an investment.

4. Going public to grow (August)

Motion: THBT companies should become public companies when they want to grow.

What it means: A *public company* is listed on the stock market, so anyone can buy its *shares* (small parts of the company). A *private company* is owned by its founders and a few investors. Going public is also called an *IPO*. The question is whether going public is the best way for a company to grow.

Clash 1 — Investment: Is going public the best way to get money for growth?

Proposition says	Going public **gives companies more money**. Many people can buy shares, so the company gets a lot of money. Unlike a bank loan, this money does not have to be paid back with interest. *Example: Amazon went public in 1997 and grew from an online bookstore into a global company.*
Opposition answers	**Money from shares is not free.** The founder may lose some control. Going public costs a lot, brings many rules, and makes the company worry about its stock price.
Opposition says	**Companies can grow without going public.** They can get money from private investors or banks and keep more control. Companies with strong technology still attract investors. *Example: SpaceX grew mostly while it was private.*
Proposition answers	**Private money may not be enough.** Private investors do not invest in every company, and bank loans must be paid back with interest. To grow very big, a company may need many more investors.

Clash 2 — Decision-making: Does stock market pressure make decisions better or worse?

Proposition says	Going public **makes companies more careful**. A public company must share important information, and a group of people checks big decisions. This stops one founder from making careless choices alone. *Example: Meta went public in 2012, then bought WhatsApp in 2014 and invested in AI.*
Opposition answers	**Too much pressure can hurt good decisions.** Public companies worry about quick results and stock prices, so managers may avoid risky but important projects.

Opposition says	**Private companies can make faster and bolder decisions.** Without stock market checks every three months, they can think long term and try difficult projects that may fail at first. *Example: SpaceX kept trying after many rocket failures and built reusable rockets and Starlink.*
Proposition answers	**Too much freedom can be dangerous.** Without enough checks, one founder or a small group may make risky decisions alone. Public company rules can lead to more balanced decisions.

5. Equality vs. equity (September)

Motion: THBT treating everyone the same cannot achieve true equality.

What it means: *Equality* means giving everyone the same rules and resources. *Equity* means giving different support based on each person's needs. Proposition says treating everyone the same is not enough, so we need equity. Opposition says equal treatment is fairer, and equity creates new problems. This is a **principle** motion, so argue about fairness and rights, not money.

Clash 1 — Structural: Do the same rules hide unequal starting points?

Proposition says	Same rules **keep existing inequality**. Rich students get private education, consulting and better information. Students from smaller cities have fewer chances. Equal rules can still give unequal results. *Example: Seoul students had about 2.6 times the admission rate to Seoul National University, and about 92% of the gap was linked to family money and private education.*
Opposition answers	Group-based help has **limits**. People in the same group can have very different lives, and some people outside the group get no help. Support should focus on each person's real needs.

Opposition says	It is **hard to set clear criteria** for who needs help. Life situations depend on many things, but public systems must use simple rules. So some people who really need help get left out. *Example: Korea's Basic Pension Act excludes some retired public officials, even ones with very low incomes.*
Proposition answers	No system is perfect, but giving everyone the same support wastes resources and fails people with greater needs. The answer is to **improve the rules**, not give up equity.

Clash 2 — Individual: Is different treatment fair, or a new kind of unfairness?

Proposition says	Equity **protects dignity and real freedom of choice**. People have different needs. Extra support removes barriers so everyone has a fair chance to take part. *Example: visually impaired students get 1.7 times more time on the CSAT, plus Braille or voice-support devices.*
Opposition answers	Dignity can be protected by giving everyone the **same basic rights**. Labeling some people as disadvantaged can create stigma and make them depend on help. Real freedom means making choices under equal rules.
Opposition says	Equity can cause **reverse discrimination**. People may lose a chance just because they are not in the group that gets support, even if they worked hard. *Example: in 2023 the U.S. Supreme Court ruled against race-conscious admissions at Harvard and UNC.*
Proposition answers	People do not start from the same place. Extra support helps disadvantaged people take part fairly. Well-designed equity policies **reduce unfair gaps** without ignoring ability and effort.